27

Léa

January 1944

Léa's fingers were as stiff as ice. There was no longer enough coal to heat the factory—all of it went to running the machines. Tucking her hands under her armpits to warm them, she then lifted the polished lens to attach it to the rangefinder's metal casing.

Her shoulders throbbed after hours of leaning over the worktable, the coal-fired pump's hum and the conveyor belt's rumble echoed in her head. She checked the white-faced clock, grateful her shift would soon end.

Léa hoped that Maria would be allowed to see Ewa at the Foreign Children's Home tonight. After each shift, Maria tried for a quick hug or kiss, or to bring food, but the home limited contact, offering excuses to keep her from Ewa. When refused, Maria spent sleepless nights worrying about her baby daughter.

Léa and Josef were concerned about Ewa's deteriorating health. Ewa was severely underweight. At first, Maria had breastfed her twice daily, but her milk supply had recently dried up. Maria heard the children ate only potato flour and thin milk. Léa remembered Josef's warning: the home was meant to isolate the children from their mothers so they wouldn't survive.

As the bell rang, ending the shift, Léa discreetly slipped a Betabion ampoule into Maria's apron pocket. She tried to give her one every week, knowing thiamine would help her baby's poor diet. Maria smiled, but the fear and despair showed in her eyes. Léa longed to comfort her with a reassuring touch, but the Meister's watchful gaze stopped her.

On her way out, she passed Lagerführer Klein and the Meister talking. From the way the Lagerführer's shoulders were set forward and rigid, and